

ENSURING COSMIC HARMONY

Chinese divination

Rulers in ancient China believed their futures were preordained by a divine will. To determine how best to align their actions with what fate had decreed, they used various kinds of divination.

Fire and bones

The earliest form of Chinese divination, dating back to before the start of the Shang Dynasty in 1600 BCE, made use of fire and bones. A heated rod was used to pierce the bone or shell, which was then placed in a fire. A seer interpreted the resulting pattern of cracks. At first the shoulder bones of oxen, sheep, or horses were used, but later tortoise shells became more common, perhaps because their shape helped diviners envisage the dome of heaven.

After divination, the question and the seer's interpretation were inscribed on the shell. Surviving oracle bones are a vital source of information about the Shang Dynasty. They reveal the identity of at least 140 interpreters, who were among the earliest magicians for whom we have a name.

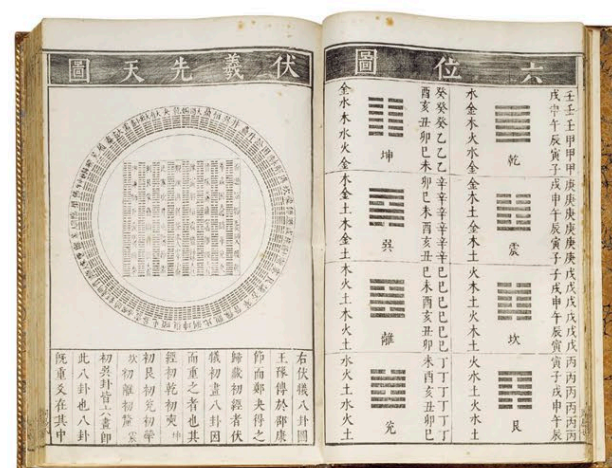
Cleromancy

A new form of divination now known as cleromancy began around 1000 BCE. This involved casting yarrow stalks to form either a solid or broken line, then repeating this action to form six rows.

◀ Shang Dynasty oracle bone

This tortoise shell, used as an oracle bone, shows characteristic cracking patterns and the archaic Chinese characters that reveal both the question and the diviner's interpretation. There are more than 100,000 surviving oracle bones.

Cracks on tortoise shell caused by fire



▲ Cleromancy in the *I Ching*

This Ming Dynasty edition of the *I Ching*, published in 1615, shows the complete set of 64 hexagrams on the left-hand page, and the name and interpretations of specific hexagrams on the right-hand page.

The resulting 64 possible hexagrams (each with names such as “cauldron” or “little harvest”) were interpreted in relation to a petitioner's question. This method of divination, linked to astrology, was preserved in the classic text *Zhou Yi* around 800 BCE; a more definitive compilation, the *I Ching*, made in the 2nd century BCE, had a huge influence as a divinatory text and as a work of philosophy.

In harmony with the landscape

In both cleromancy and divination by oracle bones, experts interpreted patterns created by human intervention. In *feng shui* (Chinese geomancy), practitioners read patterns that existed in nature, identifying features in a landscape that would lead to good or bad fortune for humans dwelling there. Burial in a grave sited in a spot where vital energy had accumulated was thought to bring the deceased's descendants good luck. On a larger scale, emperors employed *feng shui* masters to find promising sites for new cities. An isolated promontory could be vulnerable to malevolent influences, while hills might enclose and protect a site and bring blessings to the inhabitants.